

Session 1 Coaching Notes

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1. Report Format

You can do your report in a Jupyter notebook. That is fine as long as all components are included.

- What the markers do not want to see is thousands of lines of code and output with no annotation.
- The notebook needs to be really well annotated. Make it as easy as possible for the person marking it.
- Use an appendix for ancillary tables, code, and extra plots. Reference them clearly from the main text.
- Do not dump a lot of information in the appendix with no explanation. Even the appendix needs to be well annotated so the reader knows exactly what they are looking at and why it is included.
- The main body should contain core plots, tables, and findings with clear explanations and insights extracted.
- The code must be reproducible. Markers need to be able to run it.
- Extracting the key findings and figures from the notebook into the report is the clearest way to present. Both approaches (full notebook report or separate report) are accepted if done correctly.
- One team member suggested using Plotly for interactive visualisations so you can hover over charts during the report review. The coaching team said that is fine.

2. The Presentation

You will be presenting as consultants. You will be paired with another team acting as Kaluza who will ask questions in a professional capacity.

- Do not show code in the presentation. Use slides.
- This is a business presentation. Think about strategy and the business plan side of things.
- At least 2 people must present. It is entirely up to the team how many people present as long as the presentation flows well.
- Everyone should be present and contribute during the Q and A session.
- Do not have one person take the lead on everything. Show good team cohesion.
- You can have appendix slides ready in case questions are asked. You can anticipate questions and be ready with extra analysis.
- Questions could cover strategy, your assumptions, and the business plan. Be prepared to be challenged.

3. What Has Impressed the Markers in the Past

- Projects that did really well had a good balance of market research. They understood the context of Orkney, the different segments in the market, and the demographics. Demographics matter because there can be barriers to adopting the technology.
- They described the data well, explained problems with the data, and documented how they handled missing values and outliers.
- They did thorough exploratory data analysis to understand the trends in the demand data.
- They modelled the power curve and validated it.
- They linked the insights from the demand analysis directly to the business plan. There was a clear thread from context to final business plan.
- On the business side: teams that did impressive detail on costs because they really thought about the product, how it could be launched, and the impact of costs on the underlying revenue model.
- Teams that identified market segments and explained how they would market the demand response technology to each segment.
- Teams that treated this as a real product launch and built a proper marketing plan.

4. What Lost Marks in the Past

- Students who did not understand what the business issue was or why demand response technology is being used. They went off on a tangent.
- Analysis that was not connected to the business plan at all. Standalone analysis.
- Very brief plots with no explanation and no link to strategy.
- Tons of unexplained content dumped in the appendix.
- One person dominating the presentation with no team cohesion.

5. Technical Methods

The coaching team said there is no right or wrong approach. They have seen machine learning, regressions, and very basic statistics. The full spectrum.

- Simple methods are preferred. If you can achieve the same result with a simple method, that is always more appealing because fancy methods have interpretability issues.
- You will not be penalised for not using advanced methods.
- For the power curve specifically, markers expect you to show how you validated it. That is where different methodologies have been applied in the past.
- This project is really about the business plan. The data is there to support the business plan. Do not spend too much time playing with the data once you understand what is in it.
- You can mention advanced methods in the discussion section as things you could use to gain additional insights.

6. Hypotheses

This was raised during the session. The project guidelines mention a clear statement of whether your hypothesis is correct in the discussion section, and the grading criteria mentions formulation and validation of hypotheses.

- The coaching team believes this likely refers to validating the power curve model, for example confirming it is non-linear using splines or polynomials.
- This is a consulting project. You would not necessarily start with a rigid hypothesis. You are extracting insights to inform business strategy.
- The teaching team will clarify this point and come back with a response. Do not over-engineer the report around this until they respond.

7. Coaching Team Roles

- Tim Liu is the data and technical expert.
- Saadia Hyder is the business and strategy expert.
- Shameena Bonomally covers the energy side of things and will join from next session.
- They support each other across domains so feel free to ask any of them any type of question.
- Message on Teams or by email between sessions if you have questions. Do not wait until the next coaching session.
- At least 2 team members must attend each coaching session and feed back to the rest of the team.

Key message from the coaching team: The data analysis exists to support the business plan. Tell a coherent story from the data through to the final business strategy. Teams that did strong analysis but never connected it to the business plan did not score well.